Emergency that JP led. Beyond the JP legacy, if Lalu had the Muslim and Yadav combination working for him, Nitish has similarly significant cohorts of extremely backward classes and Mahadalits backing him. The saffron party, equally nimble at playing caste politics, comes up a bit short in socialist credentials, though.

So, how exactly is the party planning to fill the gap? Shah and Yogi's visit to JP's birthplace and their bitter attack on Nitish offers an insight. What they wish to do is portray the BJP as the real inheritor of JP. Not that his name alone will fetch votes in Bihar's caste-ordained politics. JP belonged to the Kayastha community, a social group with insignificant electoral strength here. But his iconic stature, as the ultimate rebel leader against Indira Gandhi's iron-fisted regime, has universal appeal, and is attractive for the BJP.

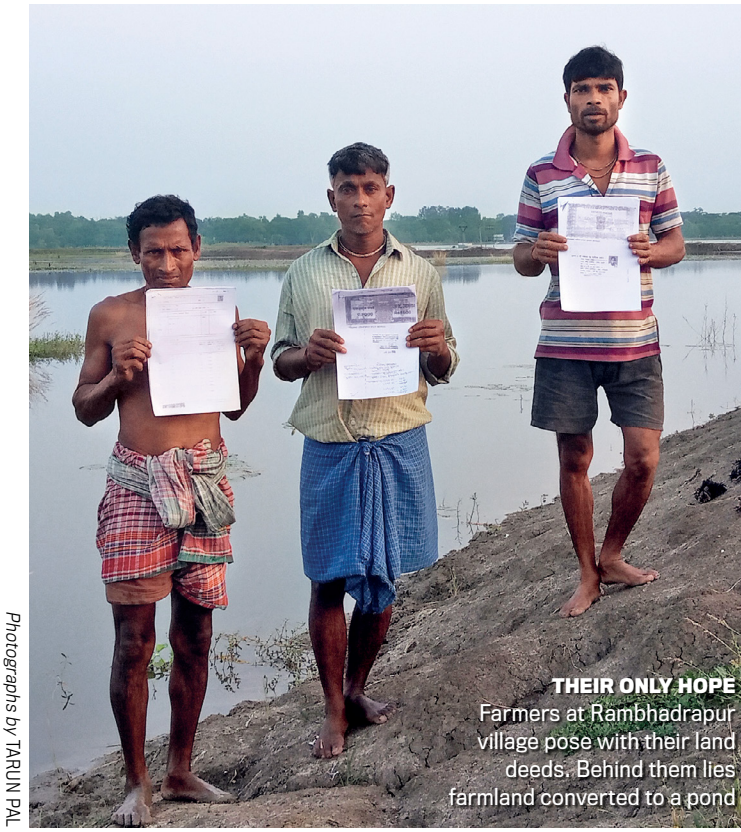
This is thus an effort to seize the moral high ground by foregrounding the 'contradiction' between JP's anti-Congressism and the pro-Congress posturing of his followers, Lalu and Nitish. The latter is not particularly shaken, though. A day after Shah's visit, Nitish said he does not attach any significance to the words of someone whose political career began just 20 years ago, years after the JP movement of 1974. "Was he in any way connected to JP or his movement? Is he in any way related with JP's ideology? How much does he know about JP?" Nitish asked, rhetorically.

SHAH'S VISIT TO JP'S BIRTHPLACE AND THE ATTACK ON NITISH SHOW BJP'S INTENT TO CLAIM HIS LEGACY IN BIHAR

Shah is no stranger to legacy politics in Bihar. In April, when Nitish was still in alliance with the BJP, the Union home minister had participated in a 'Vijayotsav' at Jagdishpur, Bhojpur district, ancestral place of Babu Kunwar Singh, the legendary warrior of 1857 whose influence carries over to neighbouring UP. But coopting JP may be a bit different. ■

WEST BENGAL

BIG FISH VS THE SMALL FARMER



THEIR ONLY HOPE Farmers at Rambhadrapur village pose with their land deeds. Behind them lies farmland converted to a pond

Photographs by TARUN PAL

By Romita Datta

The Mamata Banerjee government, which portrays itself as pro-farmer and famously opposed the acquisition of land for industry, is now being accused by some of looking the other way as land sharks forcibly convert multicrop land into fish ponds, robbing hundreds of their livelihood. The reason: pisciculture is big business in Bengal, worth crores of rupees, and is controlled by those with political clout. The irony is that Mamata's rise and the entrenchment of the Trinamool Congress in West Bengal politics happened on the back of massive movements opposing forcible acquisition of land in Singur and Nandigram in 2007 and 2008.

Around 200 out of 350 acres of fertile land in Sabang subdivision in West Midnapore district have been dug up to create seven fish ponds, each occupying 20-30 acres. Over the past three years, promoters have allegedly taken away land from several hundred farmers by force. Complaints and memoranda to the district magistrate and the superintendent of police have brought little respite, and even repeated Calcutta High Court orders to provide remedy have gone unheeded. Instead of getting succour, farmers like Shaktipada Pramanik, Tulsi Pal,